



so I gave him a business to run, and eventually, he was managing half of Magma,” he narrates. “It is an honour to have had such a great team, and I am proud of all their accomplishments.”

Creating a legacy at Magma, Rajeev managed around 1500 to 2000 people in Silicon Valley. He emphasises fairness and believes that the job of a CEO is to get the best out of everyone. He adds, “You should measure people’s performance from day one. If there is exceptional talent, you must promote and elevate those individuals as quickly as possible. The success of these individuals in future endeavours reflects on the leader.”

During his time at Magma, Rajeev was fortunate to have Mark Perry from New Enterprise Associates, one of the biggest venture capital firms in Silicon Valley, as an investor and board member. “He was the best VC you could ever have—he would give me advice, was very refined, and helped me understand the financial aspects of business,” he reminisces, admitting that he “wanted to try venture capital because of him. I thought if I could be as polished a gentleman as he was with startup founders, I would have achieved something.”

Once Magma was acquired by Synopsys, Rajeev, who had been used to making his own decisions since the age of 25, left a week after the acquisition. “Once you are tuned to being part of active leadership, being in an authoritative position without any real power isn’t interesting,” he states.

He continued investing in more startup companies until around 2014-2015, when he partnered with Chris Rust to start a venture fund. “It took me about six months to make a decision and, finally in 2016, we formed Clear Ventures,” he narrates.

Clear Ventures has partnered with around 32 companies, most of which were early-stage startups. The venture firm has raised three funds, with many companies reaching significant milestones.

Rajeev shares the secret sauce for this success. “My approach is that of an entrepreneur turned venture capitalist. A lot of VCs in Silicon Valley are professionals trained at Wharton, Stanford, or Harvard Business School, who then joined a VC fund. My view is more operational, allowing me to build a relationship with the founder and work closely with them right from the preliminary stages of startup growth,” he explains.

Inspired by his two early-stage mentors, Rajeev continues to be what Dr Bhatt and Ed Vopni were for him. A hard taskmaster and an enthusiastic cheerleader, Rajeev’s mentorship has been instrumental in changing the lives of many tech entrepreneurs who are bursting with ideas and need guidance towards the clearest path to success. **EFY**



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